

Practice Paper 26 — Answer Scheme

Paper 2 — Comprehension

Sections B & C

Note to teachers and students

- Marks are awarded for **meaning**, not for exact words. Where a quotation is required, it has been indicated in inverted commas.
- Where the question asks for **own words**, a candidate who lifts directly from the text receives **zero** for that mark unless the lifted phrase is unavoidable.
- For language and tone questions, accept any reasonable alternative that clearly fits the textual evidence.

Section B — Text 3 Answer Scheme [20 marks]

Q1. [2] — Feelings towards the kite

1 mark for identifying **pride** / a sense that the kite is **precious** (because his father made it);
1 mark for explaining the **nervousness** — he is afraid of damaging or dropping something so carefully made and valuable to him.

Sample answer: The comparison shows that the narrator treated the kite as something **precious and fragile**, almost like a **living thing he loved**. He felt **proud** to be trusted with it but also **anxious**, because he knew how easily he could ruin it.

Q2. [2] — Favourable conditions

1 mark each for any two of:

- The beach was “almost empty” (no obstacles, no other kites).
- The sun was out, even if “pale” — it was not raining.
- The wind was “strong but steady”.
- The narrator notes it is the kind of wind “grown-ups call ‘good kite weather’”.
- The kite “climbed beautifully” for fifteen minutes.

Reject: general points not tied to Paragraph 2.

Q3. [2] — “Hummed in my hand like a living wire”

1 mark for identifying the **simile** / personification — the string is compared to a **living thing**.

1 mark for explaining that the **vibration** of the taut string in his hand makes it feel as if it has its own **energy** / **heartbeat**, as though the kite itself is alive and connected to him.

Q4. [2] — “Small” and “almost polite”

1 mark — Unusual: Snapping sounds are normally described as loud or violent, and a sound cannot literally be **polite** (polite is a human quality / personification).

1 mark — Suggestion: The understated, almost gentle sound makes the moment feel **quietly tragic**: such an enormous loss begins with such a **tiny, restrained** sound, which makes it feel more **shocking** and **unreal**.

Q5. [2] — Running after the kite

(a) [1]: The adult narrator views his younger self with **gentle, knowing pity** — he understands now what the child did not, namely that **some losses cannot be reversed**, and that the running was **innocent but futile**.

(b) [1]: The personification (“politely waiting”) makes the kite seem **almost kind** — as though it pauses to give him a final chance — which makes the moment it is finally lost feel **more painful and more deliberate**. (Also accept: it reflects the **child’s hope** that the kite might still be recoverable.)

Q6. [3] — Things the father did **not** say

1 mark for identifying that listing what the father did **not** say (**negation** / contrast) creates **expectation** and then **subverts** it; **1 mark each** for **two** clearly quoted and explained details (max 2).

Accept any two of:

- “He did not say what I had been expecting” — the boy had braced himself for criticism, so the silence is a **relief** and a **surprise**.
- “that I should have held the spool tighter” — a specific reproach the boy had imagined being scolded with.
- “that I had been careless” — another anticipated rebuke that does not come.
- “He did not say anything for a long time” — the **silence itself** becomes a kind of comfort.
- “his hand resting lightly on the top of my head” — a wordless, **physical** form of kindness.

Together, these absences make the actual line — “It was a good flight, wasn’t it?” — feel **unexpectedly generous**, focusing on what was **enjoyed** rather than what was **lost**. Each detail must be **quoted** and **explained**; mere lifting = ½ mark.

Q7. [2] — “A strange and unfamiliar weight”

1 mark for understanding that the “weight” is **emotional**, not physical — a **new kind of sadness or seriousness** he had not felt before.

1 mark for explaining its nature: the **first realisation** that **something loved and carefully made can be lost in seconds**, that **no one is to blame**, and that **nothing can fix it** — in other words, his first encounter with **irreversible loss**.

Q8. [1] — Effect of the two short sentences

1 mark: The **blunt, simple sentences** mimic the boy’s **flat, stunned** state of mind; they also **emphasise the finality** of the loss — the contrast between the **vastness of the sea** and the **total absence** of the kite is made stark by the brevity.

Q9. [1] — Why no offer of a new kite

1 mark — The father understands (as the boy is beginning to) that **another kite would not be the same kite**, and that **replacing the object** would not undo the loss — “the comfort of replacement is not always a comfort at all”. (Also accept: he respects the boy’s grief.)

Q10. [2] — Looking at the empty sky

1 mark — He continues to look **even though he knows it is pointless** — which shows he is **not yet ready to accept the loss emotionally**.

1 mark — The closing simile (“the way one looks for a face in a crowd after the train has already pulled away”) shows that this small loss has marked him **deeply**; it is a moment of **quiet grief** and a kind of **coming of age**.

Q11. [1] — Tone of the final sentence

1 mark — Any one of: **wistful, reflective, melancholy, bittersweet, quietly sad**. (Reject: **angry, despairing** — these miss the gentle, reflective quality.)

Section C — Text 4 Answer Scheme [25 marks]

Q12. [2] — Nuisance vs hazard

1 mark for understanding **nuisance** — something **annoying** or **irritating**, but **not seriously harmful**.

1 mark for understanding **hazard** — a **genuine danger to health or safety**.

Together: in the past, noise was thought of as merely **bothersome**, whereas today it is recognised as a **real threat to physical health**.

Q13. [2] — “Biologically expensive”

1 mark — **Biologically** shifts the discussion from feelings to the **body** — the harm is **physical and measurable**.

1 mark — **Expensive** suggests a **cost**: the body **pays** for prolonged noise exposure with raised blood pressure, heart disease and shortened life — using the language of **economics** makes an invisible harm feel **concrete and measurable**.

Q14. [2] — How noise harms the body (own words)

1 mark: When a person is repeatedly exposed to loud or sudden sounds — even while asleep — the body releases **stress hormones** such as cortisol and adrenaline.

1 mark: Over many years this constant low-level **alarm response** damages the **heart and blood vessels**, in the same way that long-term workplace stress does.

Reject answers that lift “wears on the cardiovascular system” without rewording.

Q15. [2] — Night-time noise

1 mark each for any two of:

- The body, **although asleep**, still **registers and reacts to** noise.
- Even sounds that do **not wake** a sleeper **pull them out of deep, restorative sleep** into shallower stages.
- Sleepers therefore feel **less rested in the morning** despite a full eight hours in bed.
- Many districts exceed the night-time guideline (45 dB) **long after midnight**, so exposure is **prolonged**.

Q16. [1] — Italics on **night-time**

1 mark: The italics **emphasise the contrast** between the daytime guideline mentioned earlier and the **separate, stricter** night-time limit — drawing attention to the fact that night-time noise has its **own**, lower threshold, which is **also** being breached.

Q17. [2] — Paediatricians asking about traffic before screen time

1 mark — Screen time is currently considered **the** major concern for children’s sleep and learning, so to ask about **traffic noise first** shows it is now seen as an **equal or greater** threat.

1 mark — It signals a **shift in medical priorities**: noise has moved from being an **afterthought** to a **front-line clinical question**.

Q18. [2] — Why children are more vulnerable (own words)

1 mark: A child trying to **listen to a teacher** or **learn a new word** must struggle against a **constant background of low-level interference**, which makes learning harder.

1 mark: This **disadvantage accumulates over years**, so noisy schools fall **measurably behind** in reading and memory tasks; their **sleep** is disrupted too, compounding the harm.

Q19. [2] — “Noise radars” compared to “speed cameras”

1 mark — The comparison is **familiar** to the reader: most people know how a speed camera works, so they instantly grasp the **principle** — automatic detection and an automatic fine.

1 mark — It also makes excessive noise feel like a **recognised offence** on par with speeding, which **normalises** the idea that loud vehicles should be **enforced against** in the same routine way.

Q20. [1] — Tone of “controls entirely”

1 mark — **Firm / matter-of-fact / mildly admonitory**. (Also accept: **direct, no-nonsense**. Reject: **sarcastic, angry**.) The writer is making clear that, for headphone use, the listener has **no excuse**.

Q21. [2] — Quiet is not a luxury

1 mark each for any two of:

- Quiet is described as a **basic ingredient of physical and mental health** — therefore something **everyone** needs.
- It is placed **alongside clean water and clean air** — universal necessities, not optional comforts.
- The “resignation” of accepting noise as the price of modern life is described as **misplaced** — i.e., even ordinary city-dwellers deserve quiet.
- The closing point that **cities can be redesigned** implies quiet should be **publicly provided**, not bought privately.

Q22. Summary [13 marks total: 6 content + 7 style]

Content points (½ mark each, max 6 marks). **Eight available content points; candidates should aim for all 8.**

Ways noise harms public health (Paragraphs 2–4):

1. Loud or sudden noise triggers the release of **stress hormones** (cortisol, adrenaline), even during sleep.
2. Long-term exposure damages the **heart and blood vessels**, raising the risk of heart disease.
3. **Night-time noise** disturbs **deep, restorative sleep** even when it does not wake the sleeper, leaving people less rested.
4. Children exposed to chronic traffic or aircraft noise fall **behind in reading, memory and learning**, with effects that compound over years.

What governments and individuals are doing (Paragraphs 5–6):

5. Governments **map noise levels** and draw up **action plans** for the worst-affected areas.
6. Cities introduce **quieter road surfaces**, **night-time construction limits**, and **“noise radars” that fine loud vehicles**.
7. Authorities designate **“quiet zones”** — parks, residential lanes and hospital areas where lower limits apply.
8. Individuals can **close windows**, **choose a quieter bedroom**, use **soft furnishings**, and keep **headphone volume below 60 per cent** of maximum.

Sample full-marks summary (78 words):

Prolonged exposure to noise harms public health by triggering stress hormones that, over years, damage the heart and blood vessels. Night-time noise interrupts deep sleep, leaving people unrested, while children near busy roads fall behind in reading and memory. Governments now map noise levels, draw up action plans, install noise radars, restrict night construction and create quiet zones. Households can also help by closing windows, using soft furnishings, and keeping headphones below sixty per cent volume.

Length count: 78 words from “Prolonged” onwards.

— END OF ANSWER SCHEME —